friendly Muslim neighbour as it was of having an Afghanistan free from Bolshevik dominance.

One such example of the critical role that country played in India's security is when M.N. Roy suggested a plan to Moscow in 1920 to march a Russian 'army of liberation' into India through Afghan territory. This audacious scheme was defeated, however, when the emir made it quite clear that he would not allow Russian troops to enter his country.[69] The ability of Afghanistan to be friend or foe was, therefore, something of which the Indian government was keenly aware, and in order to make friends, it was willing to acquiesce in whatever diplomatic games Kabul wanted to play.

For the Home government, however, uppermost in its concerns was that Britain should not appear to lose prestige in its dealings with Afghanistan. That a friendly Afghanistan was important to India was acknowledged in London, but did not appear to be as crucial a factor as it did in Delhi. The Home government was unwilling to pay the price of what it deemed was Britain's imperial dignity in order to gain the friendship of the Afghan emir. Indeed, it seems that, in 1921, the Home government looked upon its Afghan relations as something of a test-case for the strength of Britain's diplomatic influence in south Asia in general. This is particularly apparent when it came to the problem of Afghanistan's relationship with Soviet Russia. While, for the Indian government, the problems of pan-Islamism and Asian nationalism were just as (if not more) important than that of Bolshevism, for the Home government, combating Bolshevik influence within Afghanistan was paramount. In this way, Afghanistan was viewed as a diplomatic battleground by London; a show-down of the political strength of Soviet Russia versus that of the British Empire.

All of which helps to explain some of the discussion that took place between London and Delhi over the issue of an Afghan treaty of friendship. As may be recalled, the talks conducted between the Afghan and British representatives in Mussoorie in 1920 had been largely seen as a preliminary to the negotiation of an official treaty of friendship between the two nations. As such it was suggested by Amanullah at the end of 1920 that a British delegation travel to Kabul to resume talks. However, if the Home government had been sceptical about the Mussoorie conference, it